
The First Great Thriller of 2026 Is Here. Will It Leave You Scarred?

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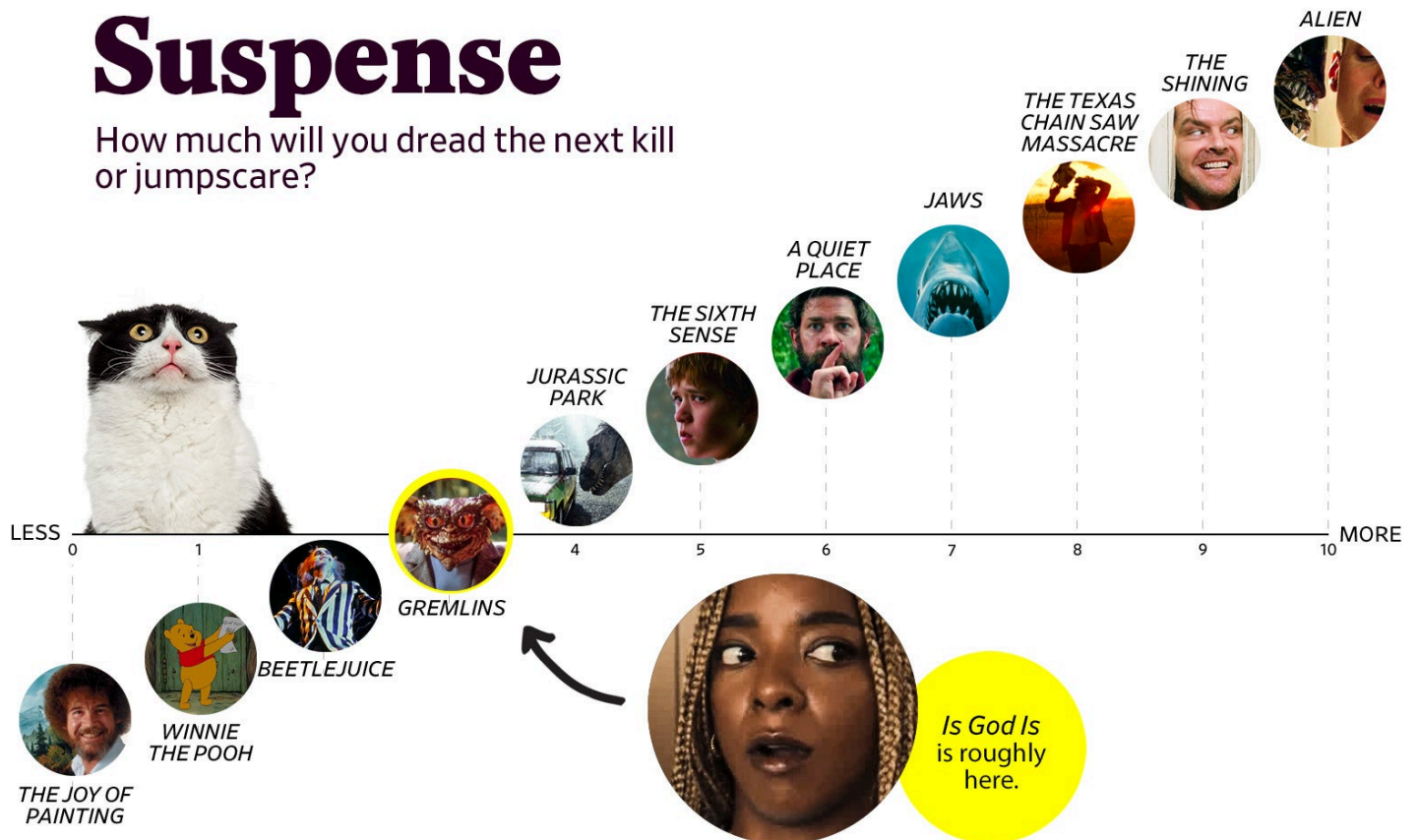
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The First Great Thriller of 2026 Is Here. Will It Leave You Scarred?

For die-hards, no horror movie can be too scary. But for you, a wimp, the wrong one can leave you miserable. Never fear, scaredies, because Slate's [Scaredy Scale](#) is here to help. We've put together a highly scientific and **mostly spoiler-free** system for rating new horror movies, comparing them with classics along a 10-point scale. And because not everyone is scared by the same things—some viewers can't stand jumpscares, while others are haunted by more psychological terrors or can't stomach arterial spurts—it breaks down each movie's scares across three criteria: suspense, spookiness, and gore.

Come one, come all, devout disciples and atheists alike, to *Is God Is*. The film—the directorial debut of Aleshea Harris, who penned the play of the same name from which the film is adapted—is a tour de force that perfectly blends [Afro-Surrealism](#), humor, and gritty drama. The story follows two twins, Racine (Kara Young) and Anaia (Mallori Johnson), who were badly burned, alongside their mother (Vivica A. Fox), in a house fire that was set by their abusive father (Sterling K. Brown) when they were young. In adulthood, the twins journey through the Black South to find their estranged father as they decide whether they will, at the behest of their mother (who serves as this story's “God”), exact their revenge by killing him. At its heart is a torrid tale about the cyclical nature of abuse. In the movie's opening scene, which tells the twins' backstory, a narrator states that the twins are still burning to this day; “they have no say in it ... they just burn and burn.” So just how gruesome does this incendiary tale get? Will the weakest among us be able to sit through the horrors to get through to the deeper meaning?



Suspense

How much will you dread the next kill or jumpscare?

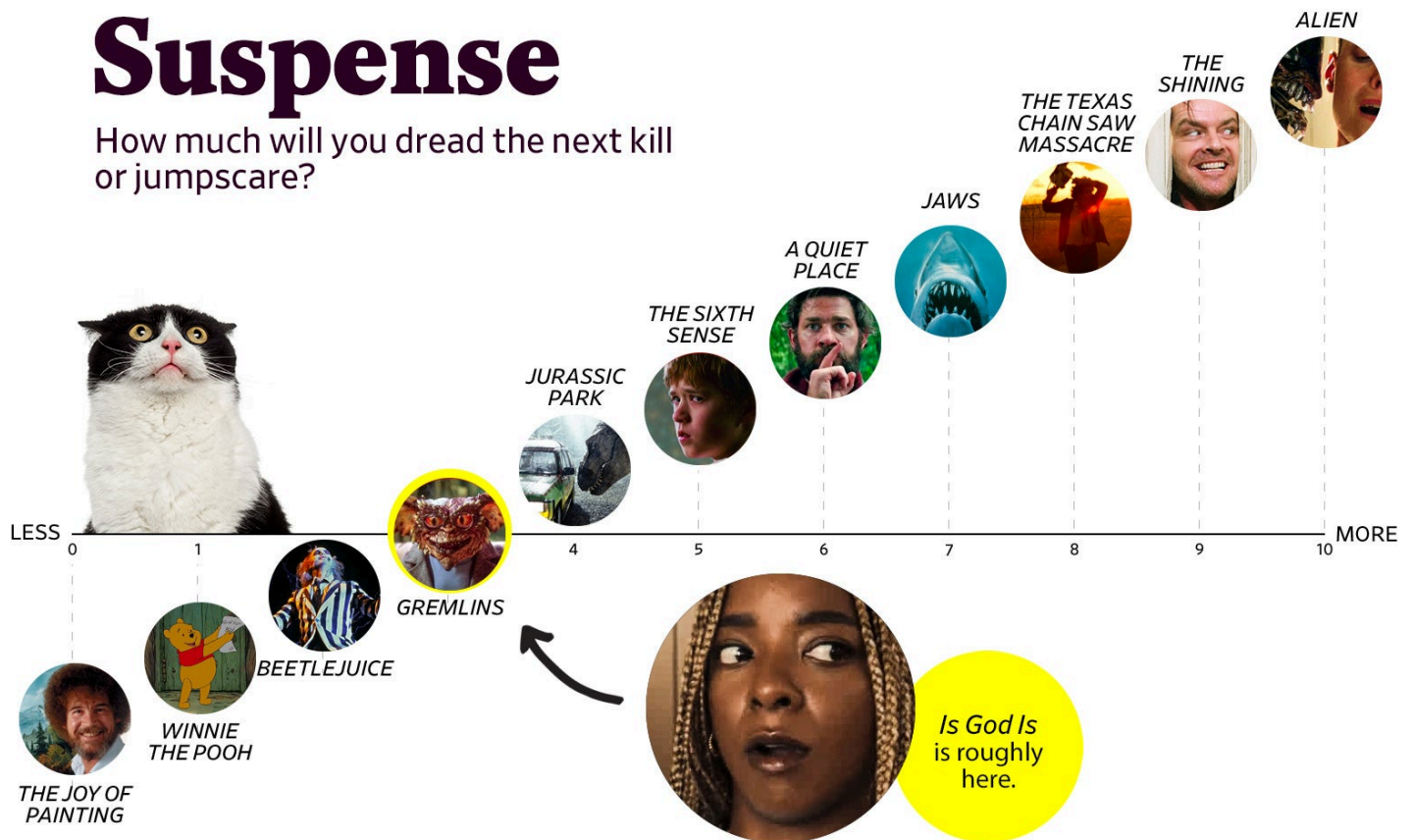


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Thankfully for the high-strung among us, *Is God Is* won't overwhelm you with jumpscare. The film contains only one scene that is akin to a traditional horror sequence—you know, the kind where you can feel that a jolt is coming because the music cuts out and the character is wandering through different rooms of their house in an attempt to identify where an ominous noise is coming from. *Is God Is* is focused more on its socioeconomic commentary on the Black South, and on subverting the character tropes we often see as belonging there, than on spiking your cortisol. The frights tend to come instead from the real-life issues it's highlighting, though those are chilling.

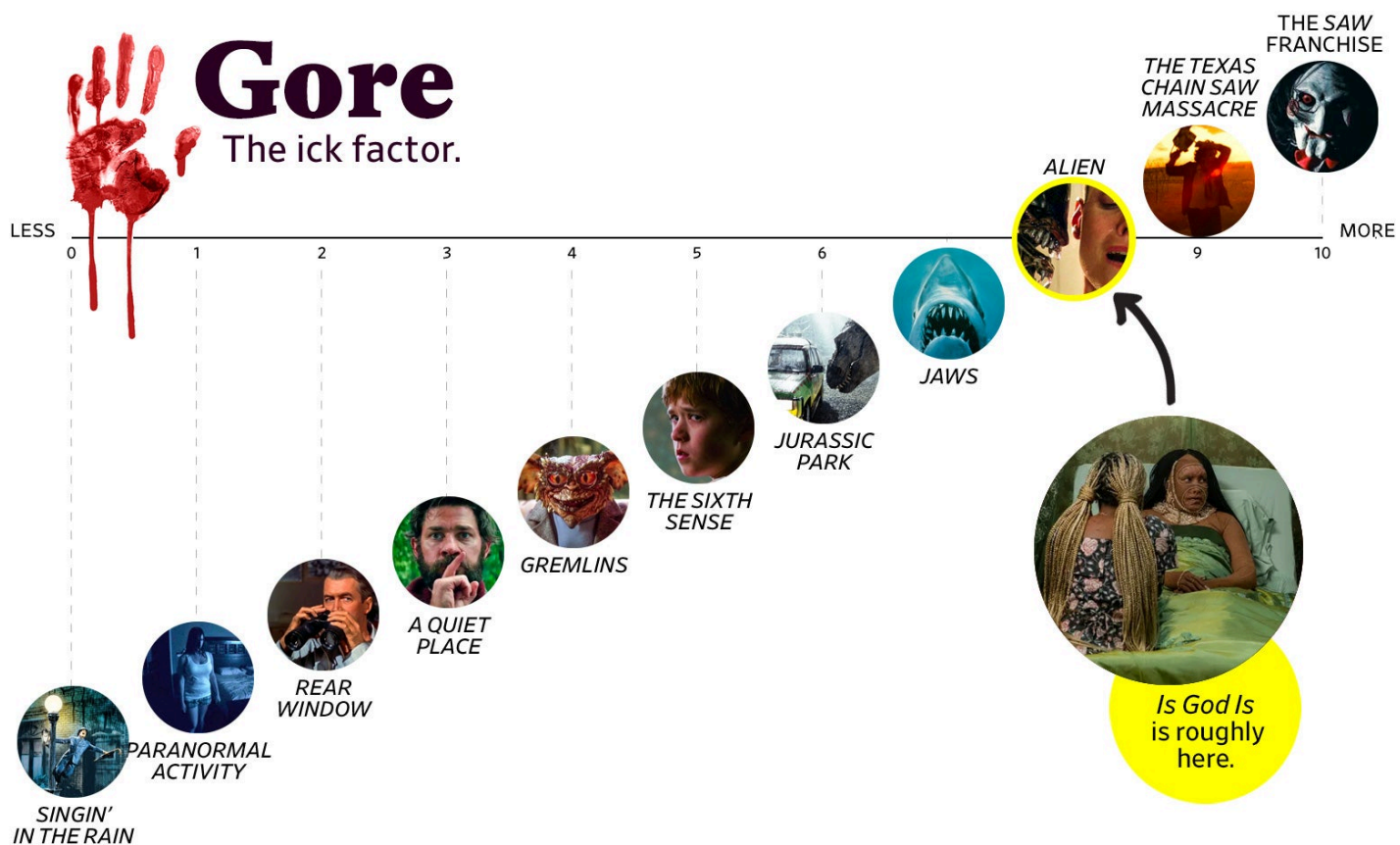
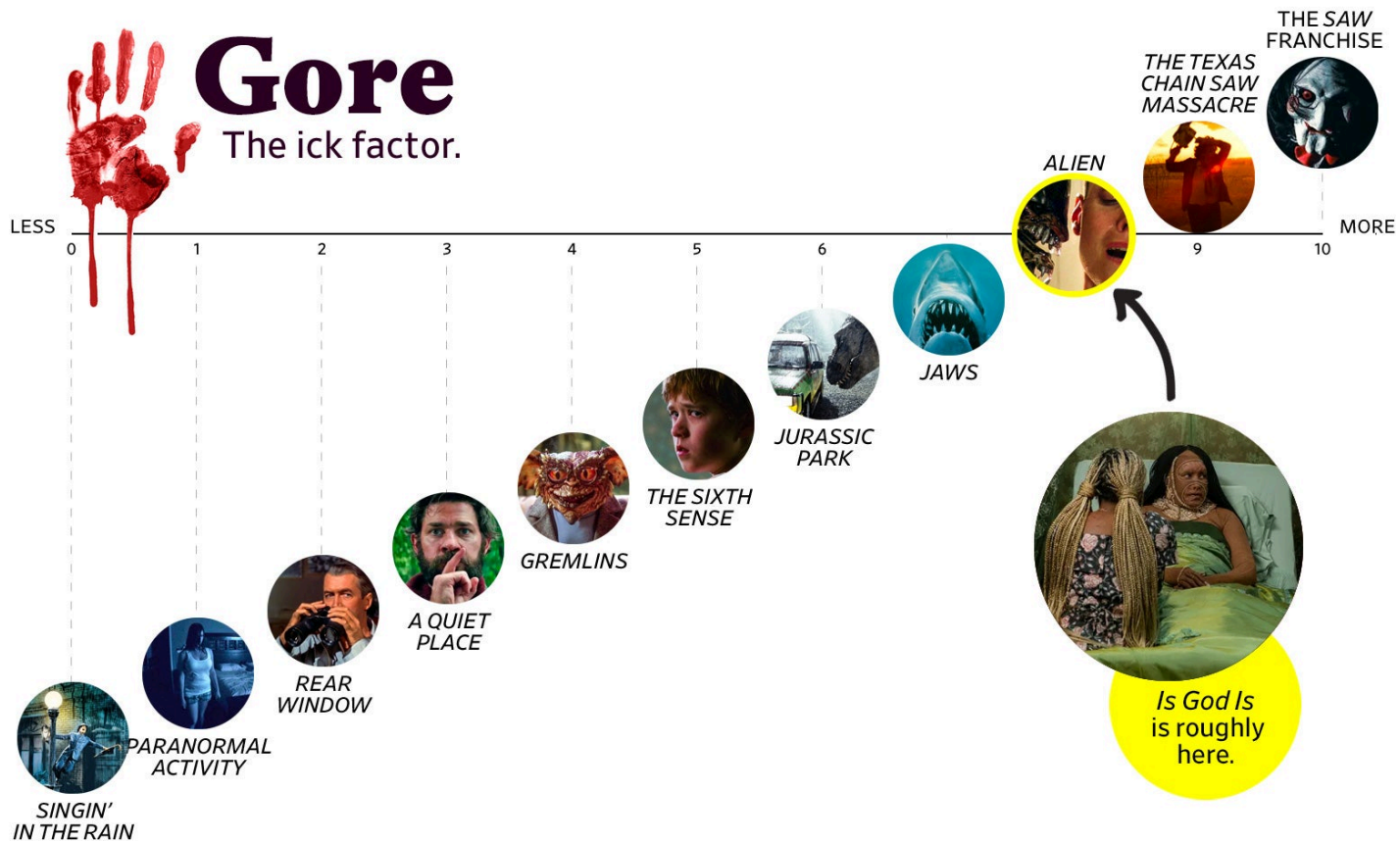
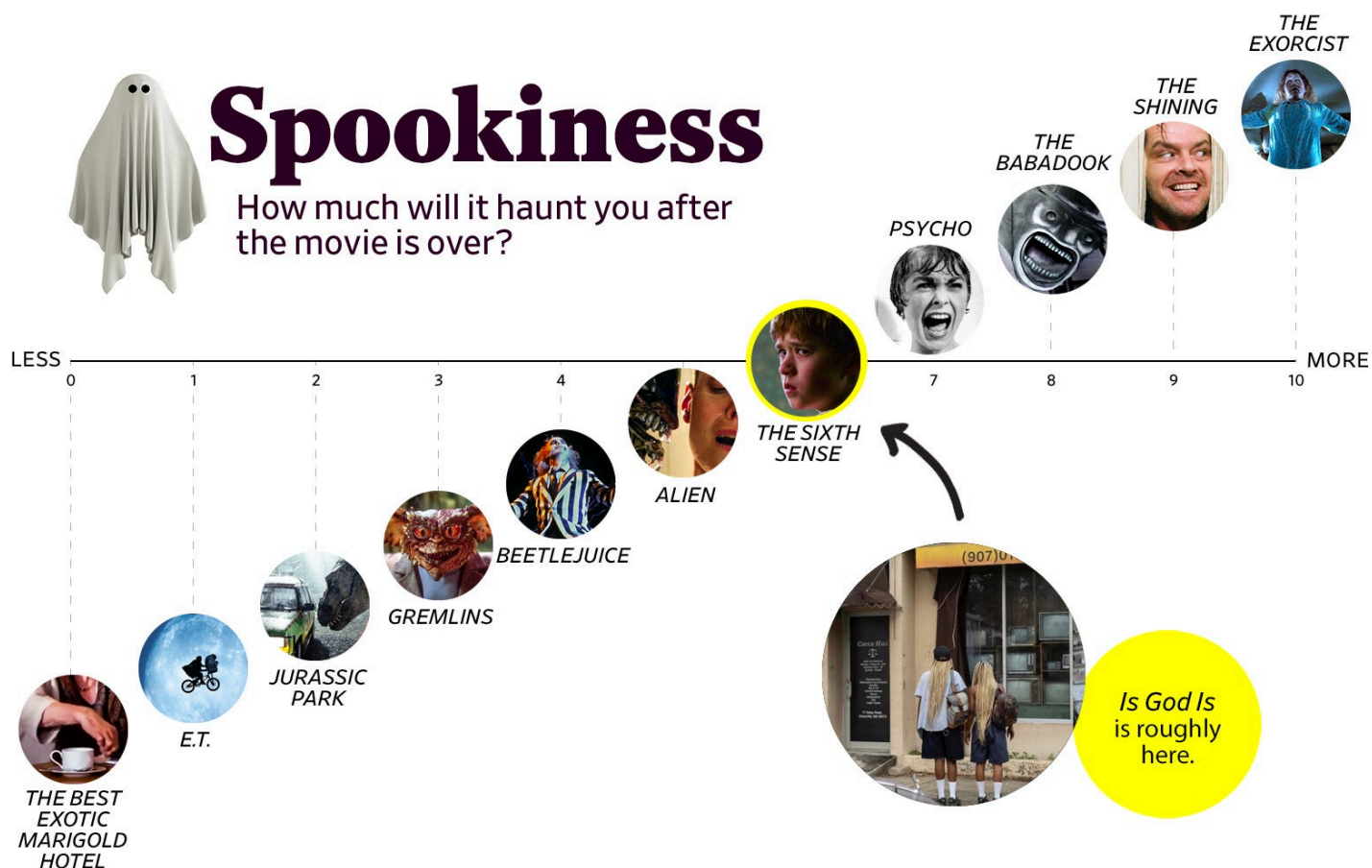


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Is God Is may not be terrifying in the traditional sense, but it is *gruesome*. Given the nature of the tragedy at its center, that should perhaps be no surprise. But it also dips a toe into body horror by considering a world wherein the characters' old wounds still actively burn enough that they rub ice on them nightly, years after the initial incident. And other grisly scenes are more unexpected, as when someone's tongue gets ripped out, or when one character beats another character to death with a rock in a sock. Though the worst is depicted off-screen—you don't actually see the tongue excision, for example—the film is very liberal with the spatters of blood. And while we might be spared some of the sights, we still must endure the sounds: The agonized screams as people are being burned, and the Foley work as bones and sinew fail to stay in their original form, could definitely linger with you. If you're easily disturbed by these sorts of images (or to narratives of abuse), I would approach *Is God Is* with caution.



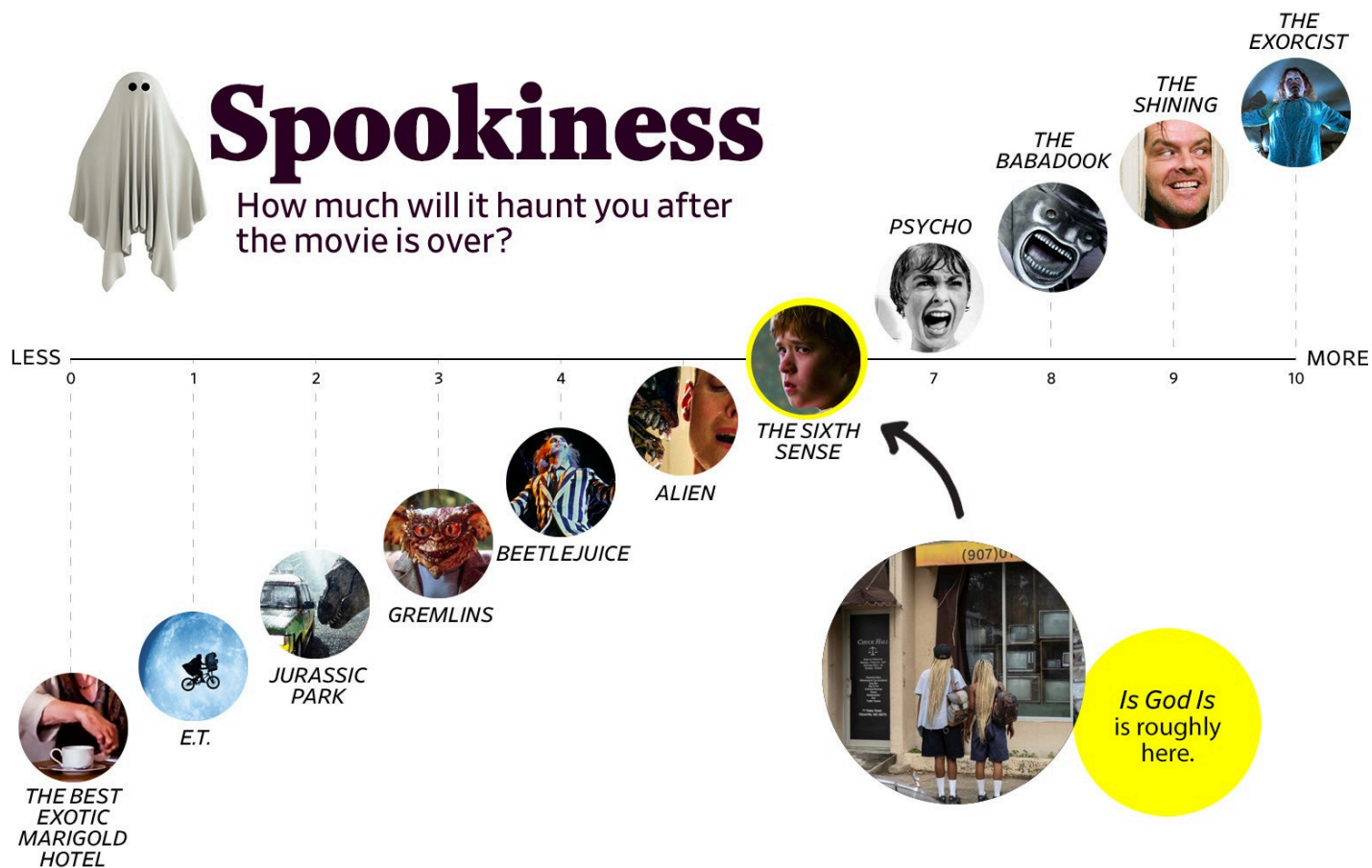


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It's hard to predict whether *Is God Is* might continue to unsettle someone after the credits roll. The film carries themes that are as old as time—notably, how violence and trauma only beget more violence and trauma—but even if it's not reinventing the wheel, this wheel ain't broke. Brown's performance as the abusive father is so good (as Brown often is), and the theme of being unable to escape the real-life demons that follow you is so palpable, that I found myself often thinking about the movie long after I left the theater. Because I'm someone who will always be more shocked by the more grounded evils of a thriller than by supernatural dangers, *Is God Is* has become an entry into that personal canon of movies that still scare me when they're long over. I remember the movie's beauty and humor as much as the darker moments, but audiences that are more sensitive to the cruelty of man: be warned.

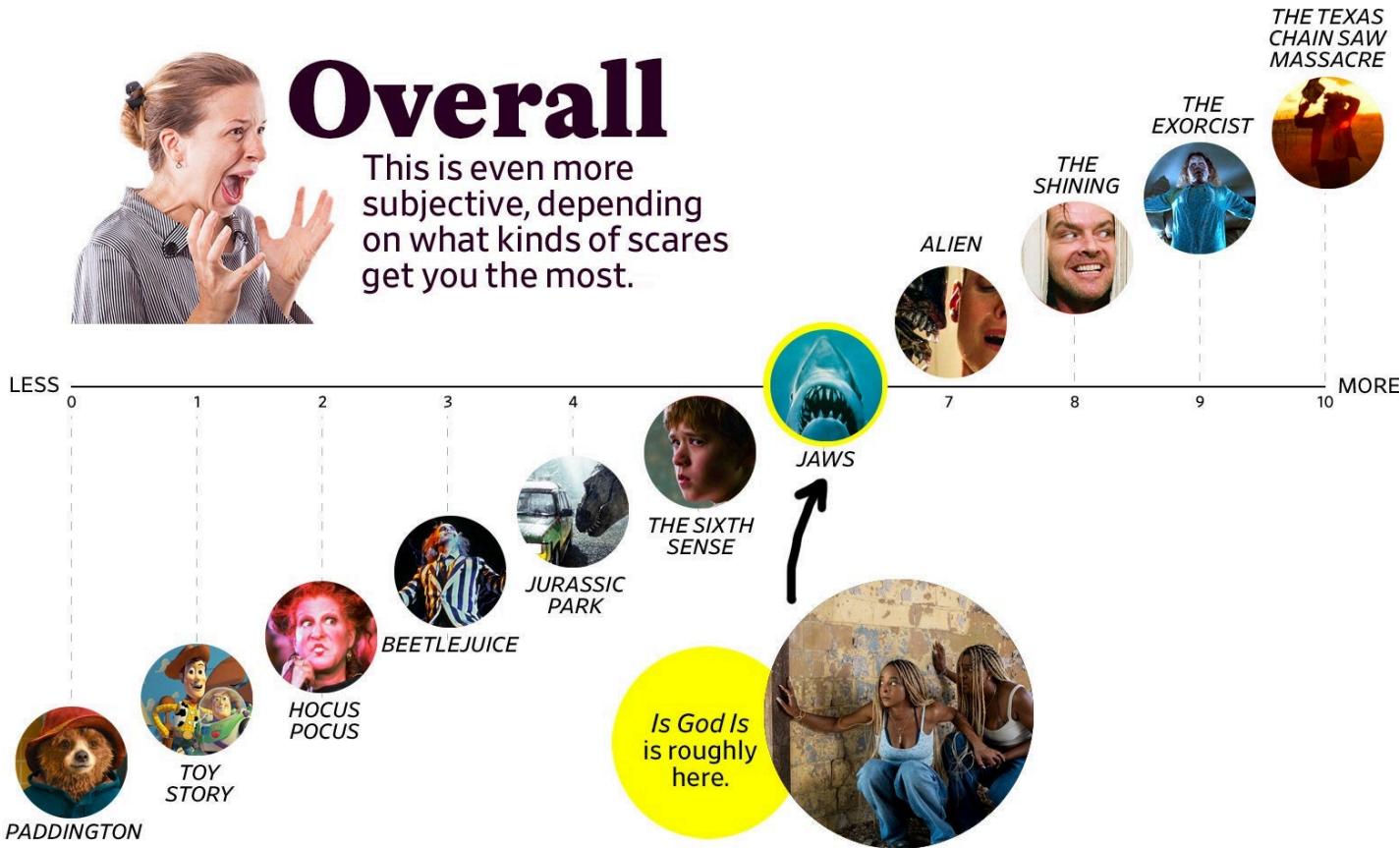
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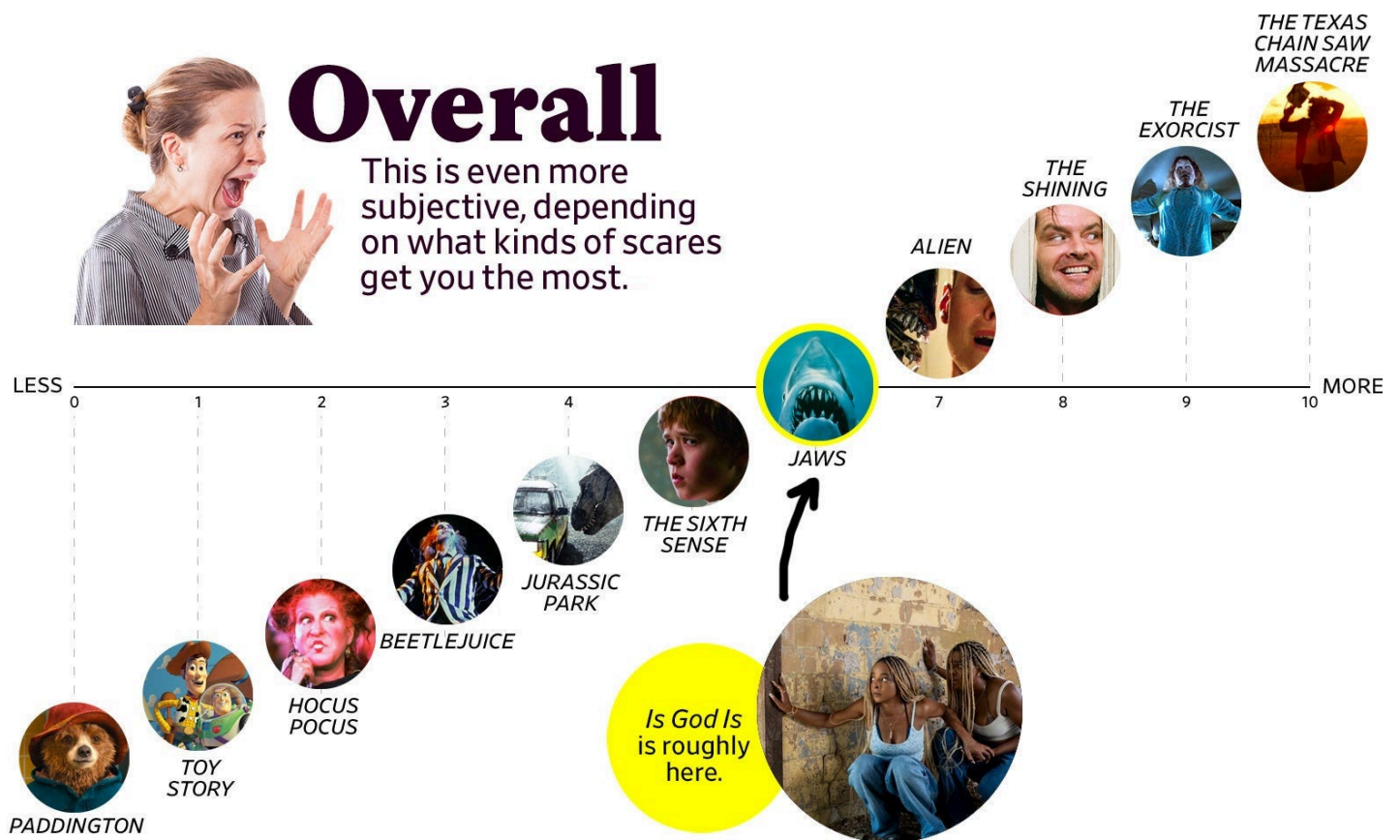


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Moviegoers who come to *Is God Is* expecting to have the living daylight's scared out of them will be sorely disappointed. However, cinephiles who enter the theater anticipating a complex, balanced meditation on the best and worst parts of the human condition will definitely find a lot to appreciate and leave with a lot to think about. *Is God Is* offers a deft rumination on the effects of domestic violence, on the devastating cocktail of psychopathic tendencies and patriarchal power that can fuel it, and on how the world treats you when your scars are something you can't hide. And still, the story is peppered with the beauty of womanhood, of sisterly bonds that last longer than the body does, of the positioning of motherhood as something so divine and magical it may just be the only accurate definition of "God." Though it has no shortage of miseries, it also says a lot about our resilience. Still, make no mistake by thinking that its ending wipes away those atrocities—they might be hard to shake.

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